whole operation to deciding on the season best suited to such an operation. In a territory as hot as Kalinga was for most of the year, winter was considered the best time to begin. This would also ensure optimal use of animals like the elephants which were an integral part of the army.[18] We do not have Ashoka's version of the size and character of the fighting force that he led. But if our knowledge of his grandfather Chandragupta's force is extrapolated to assess the grandson's, Ashoka's army had combat units of archers, foot guards armed with spears, combat commanders, horses, and large numbers of elephants under the control of mahouts.[19] Weaponry and war paraphernalia—maces, catapults, spears, swords, bows and arrows, giant stone catapulting machines—were likely to have been transported in bullock trains, which would also have carried provisions for the soldiers and animals. Imperial armies moved slowly, and given the size of the contingent and terrain the daily distance covered by Ashoka's army is unlikely to have exceeded an average of around twenty km. Pataliputra to Kalinga is a distance of some 900 km, so even just getting the army to the target ground would have taken five or six weeks.

How the army reached Kalinga has been variously imagined. Was the battlefield approached along a route that hugged the right bank of the Ganga through Bengal to Midnapur, from where the Mahanadi delta of Orissa is easily approached? This had been for centuries a pilgrim path well trodden by the devout making their way to the shrine of Jagannatha in the coastal town of Puri. Or did the army cross Chhattisgarh to reach the Ganjam–Srikakulam coastal belt on the southern edge of the ancient state, this having been the line of movement of the later Samudragupta (*c*. 328–78 CE, another emperor from Pataliputra) to Kalinga, which he invaded as he marched to conquer the southern regions? The size and strength of the defending forces that Ashoka's army encountered is very much in the realm of speculation. The description of its brutal decimation suggests it was considerable in size. If there is one thing vividly described, it is the scale of